St. Joseph's Anglo-Chinese School
F.5 English Language
Grammar – Lesson 4: Cleft sentences

Cleft sentences

Part 1: Proofreading quiz

Your teacher has put two paragraphs on the board. One argues that technology has made people lazier (Paragraph A). The other argues that technology has not made us lazier (Paragraph B). Each paragraph contains FIVE errors. The errors include relative clauses, inverted patterns and nominalisation. Proofread the paragraphs.

Everyone claims that technology makes life easier, but the truth is far less pleasant. Not only teenagers order food instead of cooking, but they also replace real conversations with emoji-filled messages. They sit for hours on apps, that were designed to save time, and end up achieving nothing meaningful. The convenient of instant delivery has destroyed any reason to walk to the shops. Rarely parents notice that their children have forgotten how to hold a proper conversation. Only when someone removes every screen from the house the family remembers what silence feels like.

Has technology really destroyed our generation, or have older adults simply misunderstood how we work? What they refuse to accept is that young people today manage schoolwork alongside online projects they could never have completed without the internet. Not only teenagers of the past lacked these tools, but they also missed the opportunities that digital platforms create. The believe that real work must involve physical sweat ignores the fact that running a website demands just as much effort. Rarely critics acknowledge that a teenager editing videos is working just as hard as someone lifting boxes. The reason because teenagers seem distracted is not laziness but the creative work they are doing on their phones. Only when adults look at the results of their work they can understand what teenagers actually achieve.

Teacher's answers

Item	Correction
1A	Not only do teenagers order food instead of cooking... (Move 'do' before the subject — 'Not only' inverts the subject and the verb.)
2A	They sit for hours on apps, which were designed to save time... ('that' cannot be used after a comma in a non-restrictive clause; use 'which'.)
3A	The convenience of instant delivery has destroyed any reason to walk to the shops. ('important' → 'importance' — a noun is needed after 'the'.)
4A	Rarely do parents notice that their children have forgotten how to hold a proper conversation. (Move 'do' before the subject — 'Rarely' inverts the subject and the verb.)
5A	Only when someone removes every screen from the house does the family remember what silence feels like. (Move 'does' before the subject — 'Only when' inverts the subject and the verb.)

1B	Not only did teenagers of the past lack these tools... (Move 'did' before the subject — 'Not only' inverts the subject and the verb.)
2B	The belief that real work must involve physical sweat ignores the fact that running a website demands just as much effort. ('believe' → 'belief' — a noun is needed after 'the'.)
3B	Rarely do critics acknowledge that a teenager editing videos is working just as hard as someone lifting boxes. (Move 'do' before the subject — 'Rarely' inverts the subject and the verb.)
4B	The reason why teenagers seem distracted is not laziness but the creative work they are doing on their phones. ('because' cannot follow 'The reason'; use 'why' or 'that'.)
5B	Only when adults look at the results of their work can they understand what teenagers actually achieve. (Move 'can' before the subject — 'Only when' inverts the subject and the verb.)

Part 2: Cleft sentences in formal writing

A cleft sentence breaks one idea into two parts so the most important information stands out. Study the patterns below.

Example 1: Wh-cleft – presenting a recommendation

Plain:	Schools should teach students how to communicate face to face.
More formal:	What schools should do is teach students how to communicate face to face.

Many teachers complain that their students cannot hold a proper conversation. What schools should do is teach students how to communicate face to face. A single workshop on active listening would help teenagers rebuild the skills that messaging apps have quietly taken away.

Class question 1 (Easy): Wh-cleft – recommendation

Simple sentence:	Schools should teach students how to start a real conversation.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What schools should do …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	What schools should do is teach students how to start a real conversation.

Class question 2 (Harder): Wh-cleft – recommendation

Simple sentence:	Teenagers need a safe space to practise speaking in groups.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What teenagers need …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	What teenagers need is a safe space to practise speaking in groups.

Example 2: All-cleft – naming the only thing needed

Plain:	Teenagers only need one real conversation to remember the value of talking.
More formal:	All teenagers need is one real conversation to remember the value of talking.

Parents often buy expensive devices or hire tutors to help their children socially. All teenagers need is one real conversation to remember the value of talking. Once they experience the warmth of genuine human connection, the cold comfort of emojis will seem far less appealing.

Class question 1 (Easy): All-cleft

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need one supportive friend to feel understood.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	All teenagers need is one supportive friend to feel understood.

Class question 2 (Harder): All-cleft

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need to feel brave for a moment to speak to a stranger.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	All teenagers need is the bravery to speak to a stranger.

Example 3: It-cleft – focusing on the cause

Plain:	People communicate less because they use messaging apps.
More formal:	It is messaging apps that make people communicate less.

Young people used to meet at the park after school, but now everyone sends messages from their bedrooms. A quick text is easier than a real conversation, so face-to-face friendships have become rare. It is messaging apps that make people communicate less, and this change will only grow deeper as technology advances.

Class question 1 (Easy): It-cleft – the cause

Simple sentence:	Young people forget social skills because they text too much.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the overuse of texting …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	It is the overuse of texting that makes young people forget social skills.

Class question 2 (Harder): It-cleft – the cause

Simple sentence:	Teenagers struggle to focus because notifications interrupt them constantly.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the constant interruptions …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	It is the constant interruptions from notifications that make teenagers struggle to focus.

Example 4: It-cleft – setting up a contrast

Plain:	Some people blame social media, but smartphones cause the real problem.
More formal:	While some people blame social media, it is smartphones that cause the real problem.

Every day there are news stories about the dangers of social media. While some people blame social media, it is smartphones that cause the real problem. Without a phone in their pocket, teenagers could not check their accounts every five minutes.

Class question 1 (Easy): It-cleft – the contrast

Simple sentence:	Some blame phones for tiredness, but late-night gaming is the real cause.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While some blame phones for tiredness …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	While some blame phones for tiredness, it is late-night gaming that is the real cause.

Class question 2 (Harder): It-cleft – the contrast

Simple sentence:	People say teenagers are antisocial, but they themselves avoid family dinners.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While people say teenagers are antisocial …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	While people say teenagers are antisocial, it is adults who avoid family dinners.

Part 3: Practice sets

Rewrite each sentence as a cleft sentence. The type of cleft to use is shown in brackets.

Set 1: It-cleft – the cause

Simple sentence:	Teenagers send short messages because they are afraid of real conversations.
Prompt:	*Use an IT-cleft.*
Teacher's Answer:	It is the fear of real conversations that makes teenagers send short messages.

Set 2: Wh-cleft – the recommendation

Simple sentence:	Students need to practise face-to-face communication.
Prompt:	*Use a WHAT-cleft.*
Teacher's Answer:	What students need to do is practise face-to-face communication.

Set 3: All-cleft – the only thing needed

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need to be confident to start a real conversation.
Prompt:	*Use an ALL-cleft.*
Teacher's Answer:	All teenagers need is the confidence to start a real conversation.

Set 4: It-cleft – the contrast

Simple sentence:	People think technology is convenient, but it actually destroys our patience.
Prompt:	*Use an IT-cleft with WHILE.*

Teacher's Answer:	While people think technology is convenient, it is the convenience of modern devices that destroys our patience.

Part 4: Writing Task

Instructions:

1. Write ONE paragraph (about 80 words) explaining the influence of artificial intelligence on students, and suggesting ONE thing schools could do to help.

→ Use **ONE cleft sentence** (It is … that … / What … is … / All … needs to do is …).

→ Use a relative clause or an inverted pattern e.g. Not only … / Never … / Rarely …

Sample answer 1 (It-cleft) Artificial intelligence is changing the way students learn, but not every change is positive. It is the loss of independent thinking that worries teachers most, as too many teenagers now let apps write their essays without even reading the questions first. Schools should therefore limit AI use in all homework tasks, which would force students to develop their own ideas and opinions. A simple rule requiring a first draft without AI would restore the value of real effort.

Sample answer 2 (Wh-cleft) What concerns parents most is that their children are losing the ability to think for themselves. Artificial intelligence can answer almost any question instantly, so students no longer wrestle with difficult problems on their own. Schools should require students to complete at least one draft without any AI assistance of any kind, which would teach them the patience that genuine learning demands. Only then will they understand that struggle is not failure but the beginning of real growth.

Sample answer 3 (All-cleft) All schools need to do is teach students how to use AI as a tool rather than a replacement for thinking. Many teenagers now trust an app more than their own judgment, which means they never develop the confidence to solve problems alone. A short practical lesson on verifying AI answers with real sources would show students that true intelligence is not about speed but about understanding. This small change could transform the way they approach every subject.

Each sample uses ONE cleft: Sample 1 an it-cleft (It is … that …), Sample 2 a wh-cleft (What … is …) and Sample 3 an all-cleft (All … need to do is …). Each sample also contains at least ONE relative clause or inverted pattern — point these out to students before they write.